

Practice Paper 45 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “A tactful witness”

1 mark for identifying the **quiet, formal, almost ceremonial** atmosphere of the room.

1 mark for explaining the **personification** — the closed piano is described as a **discreet, polite observer**, suggesting the room is one in which everything has been arranged to listen carefully but without interference.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the room felt **hushed, formal and serious**. The piano is **personified** as a polite, discreet witness, implying that even the inanimate objects in the room seemed to be quietly observing the audition.

Q2. [2] — How the panellists wished to be perceived

1 mark — They wished to appear **neutral / impartial / unimpressed** — their faces were “still” and “neutral”.

1 mark — They wished **not to encourage any candidate too early**, suggesting they wanted to seem **fair, professionally detached**, and **not easily flattered**.

Q3. [2] — “The room behaved itself”

1 mark — **Unusual:** A **room** cannot behave or misbehave; the verb is normally applied to a **person** or **child**. This is **personification**.

1 mark — **Suggestion:** It implies the first piece went **smoothly and without incident**, as though the surroundings, the instrument, and her nerves had all **co-operated** with her.

Q4. [2] — Two details that the panellists had noticed

1 mark each for any two of:

- The man on the left had **stopped writing**.
- The woman in the middle had **looked up**.

- The third panellist was **watching her**, waiting to see what she would do.
- The phrase “they had already noticed” is acceptable only if accompanied by a specific detail.

Q5. [2] — The “dignified injury” option

(a) [1]: It suggests that asking to start again would be a **socially acceptable, face-saving failure** — a small setback that would **preserve her dignity** while still ending the audition prematurely.

(b) [1]: Her refusal of this option suggests she is **composed, determined** and **unwilling to give up** — she chooses to **fix the problem and continue** rather than retreat into a comfortable excuse.

Q6. [3] — Composure while changing the reed (language question)

1 mark for identifying **calmness / methodical control**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “My hands... were not shaking” — physical **steadiness** despite the pressure.
- “as I had moistened a thousand reeds before, in a thousand quieter rooms” — the repetition emphasises **practised routine**; she falls back on **familiar habit**.
- “a single, low, exploratory note that bloomed unexpectedly” — the verb **bloomed** suggests her control is so complete that the new reed **responds beautifully** on her first try.
- “I stood up. I lifted the instrument. I began the Weber again, from the top.” — the **short, calm sentences** mirror her **unhurried, deliberate** movements.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “The way one plays at home for the cat”

1 mark for understanding that she was playing **without self-consciousness / as though no audience were present**.

1 mark for the **contrast**: she had stopped **trying to impress** the panel and was simply **enjoying the music for itself**, in a relaxed, private way.

Q8. [1] — “Floated up, hung for a second, and dissolved”

1 mark: The slow, gentle verbs suggest a feeling of **release / peaceful resolution**; she has reached the end of the piece **unhurried** and **at ease**, and the music **fades away naturally** as her tension lifts. (Also accept: a sense of **completion / quiet satisfaction**.)

Q9. [1] — Emotionally affected on leaving

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- She “walked out into the corridor on legs that did not quite belong to me” (her body still felt unsteady).
- She “started to say **I broke a reed**” — her first instinct was still to admit the failure.
- “What came out instead was, ‘I think it went all right’” — she was hesitant and tentative.

Q10. [2] — What the panel really valued

1 mark — They valued not **technical perfection** but **how a candidate responded under pressure** / **what she did when things went wrong**.

1 mark — They were looking for **composure, resilience and resourcefulness** — the ability to **recover from a mistake** rather than to avoid making one in the first place.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final paragraph

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, understanding, grateful, quietly thoughtful, insightful**.
(Reject: **triumphant, bitter** — these miss the contemplative quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Faintly absurd”

1 mark for understanding that buyers once expected goods to **last for many years** and assumed **repair** was the natural response to failure.

1 mark for explaining that today, by contrast, replacement is treated as **normal and rational**, suggesting that consumers have become **more disposable in their attitudes** and **less attached to the objects they own**.

Q13. [2] — Two design choices

1 mark each for any two of:

- Screws have been replaced by **glue**.
- Standard components have been replaced by **proprietary parts**.
- Batteries are **sealed inside cases** that cannot be opened without damage.
- Service manuals are **withheld** / treated as commercial secrets.

Q14. [2] — “Sealed boxes... invited to admire rather than understand”

1 mark — The criticism is that manufacturers have **deliberately removed the owner’s ability to look inside or interact with** the device.

1 mark — The phrase **admire rather than understand** implies that customers are now treated as **passive consumers of appearance** rather than **informed owners** — the relationship has become **superficial**.

Q15. [2] — Less than a quarter is recycled

1 mark — The figure shows the **scale of the waste problem**: the **vast majority** of e-waste is **not properly managed**.

1 mark — It supports the **environmental argument** of the paragraph by demonstrating that recycling alone **cannot solve** the problem; reducing waste at source (through repair) is necessary.

Q16. [2] — Effect of “burned, buried, or shipped...”

1 mark — The **list of three** verbs (and the **alliteration** of “burned” and “buried”) creates a **cumulative, damning** effect — each option sounds worse than the last.

1 mark — It also exposes an **uncomfortable truth**: wealthy countries **export their waste problem** to poorer countries with weaker regulation, which is **morally questionable**.

Q17. [2] — “Modest but striking”

1 mark — **Modest**: repair cafes are **small-scale, local, volunteer-run**; they do not replace industry or government action.

1 mark — **Striking**: despite their smallness, they have **spread rapidly** (more than three thousand worldwide, in many different countries), and they succeed in **repairing about two-thirds of the items brought in**.

Q18. [2] — Cultural value

1 mark — **Cultural value** refers to the **non-economic** benefits: the **sense of community**, **shared learning**, and **renewed respect for objects** that the cafes create.

1 mark — It also captures a **shift in attitudes** — encouraging people to see broken things as **worth saving** rather than throwing away, which is itself a **change in cultural habit**.

Q19. [2] — Two EU requirements

1 mark each for any two of:

- Manufacturers must make **spare parts available for between seven and ten years** after a product is sold.
- They must **publish repair manuals** in plain language.
- They must **design new products** so that **ordinary tools** can open them.

Q20. [1] — Tone of the comparison

1 mark — Any **one** of: **sceptical**, **dryly dismissive**, **gently ironic**, **unimpressed**. (Also accept: **firm but reasonable**. Reject: **angry**, **sarcastic** — these overstate the writer’s measured tone.)

Q21. [2] — Effectiveness of the closing line

1 mark — The ending **reframes** the whole article: repair is **not really about tools and techniques** but about a **deeper philosophical idea** — a **respectful relationship with our possessions**.

1 mark — The **quiet, reflective phrasing** (“a quieter idea... worth, at least occasionally, the trouble of keeping”) provides a **thoughtful, memorable close** that lingers with the reader and **invites them to reconsider** their own habits.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why modern goods have become harder to repair (Paragraphs 2–3):

1. Manufacturers **deliberately design** devices to be difficult to take apart (glue instead of screws; proprietary parts).
2. **Batteries** are now **sealed inside cases** and cannot be replaced without damage.
3. **Service manuals** are **withheld** / treated as commercial secrets.
4. The result is a **growing mountain of electronic waste** — around 62 million tonnes a year — most of which is not recycled.

How citizens and governments are responding (Paragraphs 4–5):

5. **Repair cafes** — volunteer-run community workshops — have spread to more than 3,000 locations worldwide.
6. About **two-thirds** of items brought to repair cafes are successfully **restored**.
7. The **European Union** now **requires** manufacturers to supply **spare parts**, **publish manuals**, and design **openable** products.
8. In the **United States**, individual **states** (e.g. New York, Minnesota) have passed their own **right-to-repair laws**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Modern goods have become harder to repair because manufacturers now design them to resist opening, using glue rather than screws, fitting proprietary parts and sealed batteries, and withholding service manuals. The result is a growing tide of electronic waste. In response, volunteers worldwide have set up over three thousand repair cafes, where roughly two-thirds of broken items are restored. Governments are also acting: the European Union and several American states now legally require longer-lasting, openable products.

Length count: 78 words from “Modern” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —